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THA 341: Community Theatre for Development - TfD in Practice

Make theatre with a community, not about one

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 300L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Theatre for Development is participatory, research-led and ethically demanding. This pack covers the TfD cycle, key theorists from Boal and Freire to Abah and Etherton, participatory research methods, ethics and consent, and how to document a project honestly rather than claiming impact you did not measure.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the TfD cycle from entry to evaluation.
- Apply participatory methods to identify a community's priority issue.
- Design a drama process that invites community participation and ownership.
- Evaluate and document a project with honest evidence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What TfD is and is not

Development theatre is not a health message delivered with drums.

- Community members are participants and co-authors, not an audience to be instructed.
- The issue must emerge from dialogue with the community, not from the facilitator's assumptions.
- Aesthetics matter; a clumsy play patronises its audience and loses attention.
- Facilitators hold power and must manage it deliberately.
- Sustainability depends on local ownership, not donor enthusiasm.
- Documentation and evaluation are part of the work, not an afterthought.

The TfD cycle

A repeatable sequence keeps the work honest.

1. Entry and rapport building with community leaders and groups.
2. Participatory research: listening, mapping, ranking problems with the community.
3. Analysis and scenario building with local participants.
4. Workshop, improvisation and rehearsal.
5. Performance or intervention with audience participation.
6. Reflection, follow-up and evaluation with the community.

> **Boal's spect-actor**
> Forum theatre invites spectators to intervene in the action. Learn the technique properly rather than asking the audience for 'questions' at the end.

Ethics and honest evaluation

Community work carries obligations.

- Informed consent for participation, filming and photographs.
- Anonymity and confidentiality where individuals are vulnerable.
- Avoid extracting stories for assessment and disappearing.
- Do not claim behaviour change without evidence.
- Record attendance, contributions and follow-up actions.
- Share findings and the final documentation with the community.

Theatre for development is not theatre about development

The defining difference is authorship. In conventional theatre a writer produces a script and a community receives it. In theatre for development the community identifies the problem, contributes the material, tests the solutions in performance, and decides what happens afterwards. The outsider is a facilitator, not an author, and the measure of success is what changes after the performance, not how good the performance was.

This has consequences for every stage. Research is done with the community, in its language, at times and places it chooses. The drama is built from its own stories and idioms rather than imported formats. The performance is usually followed by a facilitated discussion in which the audience interrogates the action and proposes alternatives - and may join the scene to try them.

Because the aim is change, TfD projects fail when they are evaluated only as art. The useful evaluation asks: who participated, what did they learn, what did they decide, and what did they do next? A brilliant performance that leaves no decision behind has not completed the work.

Methods: forum, image, and popular theatre forms

Forum theatre presents a short scene in which a character is oppressed and cannot overcome the obstacle. A facilitator - the joker - invites spectators to replace the protagonist and try a different action on stage. The audience becomes "spect-actors". The method works because it rehearses intervention in conditions that resemble the real ones, and because failure on stage is cheap.

Image theatre builds frozen pictures of a situation with bodies, then moves them toward an ideal image. It is useful where discussion is blocked by hierarchy or language, because it lets people show a problem before they can articulate it. Newspaper theatre takes published text and reads it against itself, exposing what a report conceals.

Popular forms - folktale, masquerade, song, dance, puppetry, market comedy - are not decoration. They are the community's existing performance grammar, and using them means the audience can follow the argument without being taught the form. A TfD project that imposes an unfamiliar naturalistic play on a village square has chosen the hardest possible route.

> **Do no harm**
> A scene about domestic violence, staged without care, can expose and endanger participants. Anonymise, consult before staging, prepare referral support, and let the community decide what may be shown.

Participation, ethics and exit

Participation is not attendance. A community that watches your play has not participated; one that shaped the script, argued with it and made a decision has. Plan participation deliberately: who is consulted, how disagreement is recorded, who speaks for those who cannot attend, and how the project avoids being captured by the loudest local voice.

Ethics in TfD are practical. Informed consent to be recorded and depicted; confidentiality where a story is personal; caution about raising expectations of funding or services; and honesty about what the project can and cannot deliver. Never promise follow-up you cannot provide.

The exit matters. A project that leaves a community dependent on an outside facilitator has failed. Train local facilitators, leave written material in the local language, connect the group to whatever support exists, and agree in advance how the work continues without you.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 341

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 341 Community Theatre for Development described under popular theatre
- Theorists named: Boal, Brecht, Kidd, Freire, Etherton, Abah, Wa Thiong'o, Colleta
- Practical work requires participation in TfD projects, with performance at the site and audio-visual documentation

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 341 Community Theatre for Development, 3 credits, first semester, 300 level
- THA 261 Theatre in Education and Community at 200 level feeds into it
- THA 369 Theatre and Development Studies appears in the course descriptions

What changed: The 2019 listing makes community theatre a 300-level core after a 200-level education and community course.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Community theatre for development remains a 300-level applied core
- Assessment usually includes a field project and a reflective report
- Confirm transport, partner communities and safeguarding expectations before fieldwork

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Designing a forum theatre session on school fees

A community identifies that students drop out because fees are paid late. Build the intervention.

1. Consult separately with students, parents and staff; the same problem looks different from each position.
2. Choose one concrete scene: a student is sent home on the day of a test.
3. Stage it so the obstacle is visible: the bursar follows a rule, the parent has no cash, the student has no advocate.
4. Brief the joker to stop the scene at the point of no return.
5. Run the forum: spectators replace the student and try approaches; record which ones change the outcome.
6. Consolidate: ask the group to name the two actions that worked and who must be involved.
7. Agree a follow-up - a meeting with the school, a savings arrangement - and who owns it.

> **What to carry forward**
> The scene must be small enough to intervene in and exact enough to be recognisable.

2. Evaluating a TfD project without inventing numbers

A funder asks for evidence of impact. What can you honestly report?

1. Record participation: attendance by group, who spoke, who joined the scene.
2. Record decisions: what the community agreed to do and who accepted responsibility.
3. Record changes in stated knowledge using a short pre- and post-session question set.
4. Record follow-up actions observed weeks later, with dates.
5. Report what did not change, and why.
6. Do not convert qualitative evidence into invented percentages.

> **What to carry forward**
> Honest evaluation is narrower and far more convincing than fabricated impact figures.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Distinguish theatre for development from conventional theatre in purpose, process and evaluation.

20 marks

1. Purpose: change versus presentation.
2. Process: community authorship and facilitation versus script and direction.
3. Form: local performance grammar versus imported conventions.
4. Evaluation: decisions and actions versus aesthetic reception.
5. Conclude that the distinction is structural, not a matter of subject matter.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Defining TfD by its themes. A play about health is not automatically TfD.

Q2. What are the ethical risks of staging a community's problems, and how are they managed?

15 marks

1. Risk of exposure and stigma for identifiable participants.
2. Risk of raising unmet expectations about funding or services.
3. Risk of amplifying one voice and silencing others.
4. Controls: consent, anonymisation, consultation, referral support, community veto, honest exit plan.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Theatre for development. Participatory performance made with a community to examine and act on its own problems.

Facilitator. The outside practitioner who supports a community's authorship rather than imposing a script.

Forum theatre. A method in which spectators replace the protagonist and test alternative actions on stage.

Joker. The facilitator who runs a forum theatre session and manages the interventions.

Spect-actor. An audience member who becomes a participant by entering the scene.

Image theatre. Building frozen physical pictures of a situation and reshaping them toward a desired state.

Newspaper theatre. Staging published text so that its assumptions and omissions become visible.

Popular theatre. Performance using a community's own forms, such as song, dance, masquerade and folktale.

Informed consent. Agreement to participate given with full knowledge of how material will be used.

Anonymisation. Removing identifying detail so that a contributor cannot be recognised.

Sustainability. The project's ability to continue through local capacity after external facilitation ends.

Exit strategy. The agreed plan for handing over skills, material and relationships at the end of a project.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Enter

Consultation.

- Meet three stakeholder groups separately.
- Record the problem in their words.
- Identify who is not being heard.

Week 2 - Build

Scene-making.

- Choose one concrete scene.
- Draft it with community members.
- Test it in front of a small group.

Week 3 - Perform

Forum.

- Brief the joker on the stop point.
- Run the intervention.
- Record decisions and who owns them.

Week 4 - Follow up

Honest evaluation.

- Collect follow-up evidence with dates.
- Write the report including what did not change.
- Hand over materials and contacts.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Augusto Boal, Theatre of the Oppressed - for forum and image theatre methods.
- Any African TfD case study collection covering participatory methodology.
- Your institution's research ethics guidance for community-based work.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Who owns a TfD project?

Answer: The community, with the facilitator supporting their process and decisions; not the facilitator or the sponsor.

2. What is forum theatre?

Answer: A participatory form where spectators become 'spect-actors' and intervene in the action to test alternative solutions to an oppression.

3. Why is participatory research essential?

Answer: It surfaces the community's own priorities and language, preventing a project that solves a problem nobody identified.

4. Give two ethical requirements for documenting a TfD project.

Answer: Informed consent for participation and media, and protecting the anonymity of vulnerable participants.

5. Why avoid claiming behaviour change without evidence?

Answer: It misrepresents impact, undermines trust and makes the work impossible to evaluate or repeat honestly.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Read one TfD case study and summarise its cycle.
- [ ] Draft a participatory research plan.
- [ ] Write consent and release forms.
- [ ] Facilitate one improvisation workshop with peers.
- [ ] Document a session with notes, photos and attendance.
- [ ] Write an evaluation plan that names your indicators.
- [ ] Present findings to the group you worked with.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: